transfer of Rs 6,000 a month. Another plank the party is exploring is to vastly improve the country's health and education facilities through government spending. The Congress now needs to prepare a blueprint for rapid social and economic development apart from political reform to successfully challenge the BJP's vision of growth.

It will, however, be the political role that Rahul will play in the coming months that will be make-or-break for both him and the party. As Jairam points out, "While Rahulji has fashioned an ideological and moral role for himself during the yatra, he now has to fashion a political role. That is the big imperative." Though Rahul eschewed electoral politics during the yatra, he showed shades of his approach towards resolving inner-party conflict in some of the states it passed through. For instance, while in Karnataka, Rahul put his arms around the two warring leaders in the state—former chief minister Siddaramaiah and state party chief D.K. Shivakumar—and told them, "Siddaramaiahji, tell me what are the best qualities of Shivakumar, and Shivakumar, you tell me, what's best about your former chief minister." In Rajasthan, he involved Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot and his arch-rival Sachin Pilot in a discussion, describing both of them as "assets of the party". In Haryana, unlike in the 2019 assembly election, sources say he has allowed former chief minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda far more leeway in organisational matters and ticket distribution to prepare for the 2024 state election. Psephologist Gupta believes the real benefit of the yatra is that it has given Rahul Gandhi the moral legitimacy to deal with organisational issues and personality tussles with clarity and firmness, and to act decisively on party matters.

He and the party will have to demonstrate their new-found intent with the nine states going to the polls this year. "If the party cannot win a couple of important states in 2023, it's not even in the fight for the 2024 general election. Without a victory, it cannot even present itself as a credible alternative to the voters and to other Opposition parties at the time of forming alliances," says Rahul Verma. In UP, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav and Bahujan Samaj Party chief Mayawati declined to join the yatra despite the Congress invitation. The grand old party is now aiming for one big show of Opposition unity. It has invited leaders of 21 like-minded parties to join the concluding ceremony of the yatra in Srinagar on January 30. The list of attendees will be an indication of the party's acceptance as the pivot of Opposition unity.

In fact, the party's acceptance and position among other Opposition parties depends on finding a solution to the dichotomy that exists in the six states where the Congress is involved in a direct contest with the BJP. These states—Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Rajasthan, MP, Gujarat and Chhattisgarh—account for 100 Lok Sabha seats. In 2018, the Congress won assembly polls in Rajasthan, MP and Chhattisgarh. Yet, in the past two Lok Sabha elections, the party could win only three out of these 100 seats, clearly indicating that in a direct contest between PM Modi and Rahul Gandhi, the latter stands little chance in these north Indian states. "The future of this country is linked to the outcome of 2024 and the outcome of 2024 is linked to the performance of the Congress. If the Congress can win at least 30 out of the 100 seats in these six states, the BJP will struggle even to reach the majority mark," says Yogendra Yadav. In the longer run, the Congress has to reverse its fortunes in six politically significant major states—UP, Bihar, West Bengal, Odisha, Maharashtra and Telangana—if it has to become an important national player again. The party believes it has ceded too much space to alliance partners in some of these states and will now push for a more equal partnership that recognises the centrality of the Congress in the Opposition arena. But first it has to build its own organisational muscle. The yatra has made people sit up and take notice. But for the interest to sustain, it must yield political dividend, lest it be dismissed as just another image-building exercise by the Gandhi family. ■



SHOW OF UNITY Telangana CM KCR with opposition leaders at the Bharat Rashtra Samithi rally in Khammam, Jan. 19

– with **Rohit Parihar, Rahul Noronha and Dhaval S. Kulkarni**